Topic 1: The AI Tools Landscape

1.1 Categories of AI Productivity Tools

- Text / writing assistants: ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini -- general-purpose AI chat and writing
- Coding assistants: GitHub Copilot, Cursor, Codeium -- AI inside your code editor
- Image generation: DALL-E 3, Midjourney, Stable Diffusion, Adobe Firefly -- text-to-image
- Research and search: Perplexity AI, NotebookLM, Elicit -- AI-enhanced information retrieval
- Productivity suites: Microsoft 365 Copilot, Google Workspace AI -- AI embedded in Office tools
- Meeting and audio: Otter.ai, Fathom, Fireflies.ai -- transcription and meeting summaries

1.2 Choosing the Right Tool for Your Task

- Text tasks: try ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini -- each has strengths; the best choice depends on your specific task
- Image tasks: Midjourney (artistic quality), DALL-E 3 (precise/literal), Stable Diffusion (customisable and free)
- Coding: GitHub Copilot in your editor for completions; Claude or ChatGPT for explanations and debugging
- Research with citations: Perplexity AI; research within your own uploaded documents: NotebookLM
- Office productivity: Microsoft Copilot if you use Microsoft 365; Google Gemini if you use Google Workspace
- Rule: use the AI that is already inside your existing workflow -- adoption beats perfection

1.3 Privacy and Security Basics

- Free public AI tools: your inputs may be used to improve models by default -- check and update privacy settings
- Never paste confidential data, PII, passwords, or API keys into public AI chat interfaces
- Enterprise / Team tiers: ChatGPT Team, Claude for Work, Google Workspace AI include contractual data privacy
- Local models: Ollama (ollama.com) runs Llama 3, Mistral, and others entirely on your machine -- no data leaves
- Treat AI tools like any other third-party SaaS: review the terms of service before using with sensitive data

1.4 Building an AI Habit

- Start with one tool, use it daily for 2 weeks before adding others -- depth before breadth

- Identify your 3 most time-consuming recurring tasks and experiment with AI for each one
- Track your experience: what worked, what did not, what prompts produced the best results
- Share workflows with colleagues -- AI productivity compounds when teams adopt consistent practices together
- Expect imperfect output: AI tools produce errors regularly; always review output before using it

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